

Empiricism — Answer-Writing Toolkit

Fourteen verified PYQs and six original solved models

This is the topic's solved Mains/PYQ workbook and transfer manual. All 14 directly owned verified PYQs through 2026 receive complete independent model answers. These are learner practice, never official UPSC answer keys. Kant, Hegel, Moore and Russell are cross-topic comparison components, not duplicate primary owners.

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What to recall and what to write

Demand	Recall first	Write for marks
Locke on knowledge	ideas; agreement; three degrees	define the mode of perception; distinguish certainty from probability
Locke on substance/qualities	primary/secondary; powers; substratum	separate explanatory distinction from resemblance claim
Locke on self/God	consciousness; forensic person; demonstration	use prince/cobbler, objections and causal premise
Berkeley	anti-abstraction; five arguments; notions	derive immaterialism before objections; explain God's two jobs
Hume on knowledge	impressions/ideas; association; fork	run the copy test; separate relations of ideas from matters of fact
Hume on self/causation	bundle; Appendix; custom; two definitions	show the missing impression, natural belief and residual problem
Comparative demand	shared rule + added premise	complete the empiricist case before Kant/Hegel/Moore/Russell

Must-write keywords

Locke: white paper; sensation; reflection; simple/complex ideas; modes, substances, relations; agreement/disagreement; intuitive, demonstrative, sensitive; representative realism; abstraction; nominal/real essence; primary/secondary qualities; power; substratum; consciousness; forensic identity; demonstrative proof.

Berkeley: anti-abstraction; selective attention; sensible things; immediately perceived; to be is to be perceived (*esse est percipi*); semantic, likeness, parity, Master and continuity arguments; ideas/passive; spirits/active; notion; divine language; anti-scepticism.

Hume: impressions; ideas; copy principle; missing shade; association; relations of ideas; matters of fact; constancy/coherence; bundle; resemblance/causation; Appendix; priority, contiguity, constant conjunction; impression of reflection; custom/habit; induction; mitigated scepticism.

High-value analytical lines

- Empiricism regulates the **origin of simple content**, not every operation or achievement of reason.
- Locke's external world occupies his weakest degree of knowledge, which explains why Berkeley's attack begins inside rather than outside Lockean epistemology.
- Berkeley's immaterialism is anti-sceptical: it abolishes the unknowable material duplicate, not the experienced world.
- Hume does not simply abolish necessity; he relocates it from objects to the mind's felt transition.
- Hume's Appendix exposes the common cost of atomism: relations and unity cannot be recovered from perceptions first treated as self-contained atoms.

- Kant answers Hume by making causal order a condition of possible experience, not an impression copied from experience.

Introduction bank

1. "British empiricism is one origin-of-content rule applied with increasing severity to knowledge, substance, self, God and causal necessity."
2. "Locke retains represented matter, Berkeley removes matter to save the experienced world, and Hume explains why beliefs survive after their rational warrant has failed."
3. "The central empiricist dispute is not whether experience matters, but what experience can justify beyond its immediately given contents."

Conclusion bank

- "Locke's settlement is practically confident but theoretically exposed at the representative gap."
- "Berkeley defeats the veil of perception only by making spirit and God carry the explanatory load."
- "Hume's mitigated scepticism is not paralysis: nature sustains the beliefs philosophy cannot prove."
- "Kant's response is powerful precisely because it accepts Hume's anti-dogmatism while rejecting his reduction of necessity to habit."

Redrawable diagrams and answer spines

experience -> Locke's represented matter -> Berkeley's ideas + spirits
 -> Hume's perceptions + custom -> Kant's conditions of experience

10 marks: define -> 2-3 doctrinal moves -> one qualification -> verdict
 15 marks: reconstruct argument -> objection/reply -> comparison where demanded -> judgement
 20 marks: conceptual map -> complete derivation -> named reactions -> explicit contrast -> verdict

Argument/counterargument table

Claim	Strong objection	Best reply	Remaining difficulty
Locke's ideas resemble primary qualities	comparison with an unperceived original is impossible	structural correspondence, not pictorial likeness	Locke's own resemblance wording remains exposed
Consciousness constitutes personal identity	memory presupposes identity and breaks transitivity	overlapping chains/capacity distinguish criterion from evidence	metaphysical bearer remains unsettled

Claim	Strong objection	Best reply	Remaining difficulty
Berkeley can conceive only perceived objects	Master Argument confuses conceiving an object with conceiving it unconceived	it targets meaningful access to absolute existence	critics can reject Berkeley's semantic premise
Spirit is known by notion	notion is an ad hoc exemption	activity cannot be represented by a passive idea	positive content of spirit remains thin
Causal necessity is mental determination	science requires objective order	Hume explains practice naturalistically	justification of induction remains unavailable
Kant supplies objective causality	categories may merely relocate the problem	they are conditions of experience, not hypotheses	noumenal causality remains unknowable

Self-check rubric

Score 0–2 on: exact demand; doctrinal accuracy; complete argument; textual/source anchor; objection and reply; explicit qualification; useful diagram/comparison; signed verdict; exam-length control. **14–16**: ready; **10–13**: repair named cells; **below 10**: return to the Revision Guide and retry closed-book.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline — read once, applies to every solution below

Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is **never** an official UPSC key. Question wording is reproduced exactly as printed in the official papers; the 2019, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025 Paper I texts were read directly from the official question papers held in books\philosophy_optional\, and the 2018 and 2020 parts follow the repository's verified Western Philosophy PYQ ledger because those two Paper I question papers are not present locally. Doctrinal claims are attributed to their *Essay Book.Chapter.Section*, *Principles* section or *Treatise/Enquiry* location, and interpretive disputes — whether Locke's substratum is a humble posit or an empty placeholder, whether the Master Argument proves anything beyond a scope confusion, whether Hume is better read as a destructive sceptic or as a naturalist — are flagged as contested rather than settled.

Answer-length convention used throughout this package. UPSC Philosophy Paper I parts are written longer than General Studies answers. The working bands are **10 marks — about 150 to 200 words**, **15 marks — about 250 to 300 words**, and **20 marks — about 340 to 400 words**. Every solution below sits inside its declared band, and the demand decoding, the verdict heading and the "why this earns marks" notes are teaching apparatus that sit **outside** the timed word count.

Coverage: fourteen directly owned Empiricism PYQs from 2018 to 2026 — every part the ledger routes to this syllabus item, in every year of the corpus — and six original solved Mains models, two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks.

Citation discipline used in every answer. Locke is cited by Book.Chapter.Section of the *Essay* (II.i.2, II.viii, II.xxiii.2, II.xxvii.9, III.iii.6–11, IV.vii.9); Berkeley by section of the *Principles* (Intro §§6–25, and §§3, 8, 9–15, 22–23, 27, 30–33); Hume by *Treatise* Book.Part.Section (I.i.1, I.iii.14, I.iv.2, I.iv.6, Appendix) and by *Enquiry* Section (II, IV, V, VII, X, XII). Latin tags that are later labels rather than the author's own words are marked as such.

2018 · Q1(a) · 10 marks

Question: Are the two truths—'The Sun will rise tomorrow' and ' $2+2=4$ ' of the same necessity for Hume? Give reasons in favour of your answer.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Are they ...? Give reasons" — a direct verdict in the first line, then justification
Core issue	Whether Hume's fork admits degrees of necessity or two different kinds
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the fork, the conceivability test, the induction consequence, one verdict
Ideal thesis	No — they belong to different classes, and the difference is in kind, not in degree of evidence
Non-negotiables	Relations of ideas versus matters of fact; denial-contradiction versus conceivability; custom; no appeal to "more probable"

Independent model answer

No. For Hume the two propositions fall on opposite sides of a division that admits no intermediate case.

" $2+2=4$ " states a **relation of ideas**. It is discoverable by thought alone, its truth does not depend on anything existing in the world, and its denial is self-contradictory. Necessity here is absolute and its warrant is *a priori*.

"The Sun will rise tomorrow" states a **matter of fact**. Its contrary — that the Sun will not rise — implies no contradiction whatever and is perfectly conceivable, which is Hume's operative test. No amount of past regularity converts conceivable falsehood into impossibility.

The reason is structural. Every factual inference beyond present sense and memory runs through cause and effect, and causal inference presupposes that the future will resemble the past. That principle cannot be demonstrated, since its denial is conceivable, and cannot be established from experience without circularity. What sustains the expectation is **custom or habit**, not reason.

So the necessity attaching to the sunrise is psychological — a felt determination of the mind — while the necessity of the arithmetical truth is logical.

Verdict. ⚠ Not of the same necessity: one is demonstrative, the other an unavoidable expectation grounded in habit.

Qualification and criticism

note that the fork is a classification, so the result is as secure as the fork itself.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2018 Q1(a): the question is a yes/no, and it must be answered before it is explained. A script that describes the fork without ruling has answered a different question.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: verdict in one line; each proposition placed in two or three lines; the induction consequence in four; the closing distinction in one.

- **Structure:** verdict → classification of each proposition → the reason the classification holds → distinction of the two necessities.
- **Doctrine:** relations of ideas; matters of fact; the Uniformity Principle; custom.
- **Evidence:** conceivability of the contrary as the operative test; *Enquiry* IV and V.
- **Distinction:** logical necessity versus a psychological determination of the mind.
- **Criticism:** note that the fork is a classification, so the result is as secure as the fork itself.

2018 · Q3(a) · 20 marks

Question: How does Berkeley establish that Mind and its ideas alone are real? How do Moore and Russell react to Berkeley's view in this regard? Do you find any difference between Moore's reaction and Russell's one? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Three limbs: establish, react, difference — all three must appear
Core issue	The derivation of immaterialism, and two distinct twentieth-century refusals of it
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: five arguments compressed, two reactions, one explicit contrast, one verdict
Ideal thesis	Berkeley's case is cumulative; Moore rejects the inference, Russell rebuilds the object — they differ in what they preserve
Non-negotiables	Anti-abstraction; <i>Principles</i> §§1–4, 8, 9–15, 22–23, 30–33; act-object distinction; logical construction

Independent model answer

Berkeley's case is cumulative, and it begins before metaphysics. In the Introduction to the *Principles* he denies **abstract general ideas**: we may separate what could exist apart — a hand from a body — but not extension from colour, motion from determinate speed, or "man" from every determinate stature. Locke's *material substance in general* is exactly such an abstraction, compounded from the abstract idea of being and the relative notion of supporting, so "matter" is not an unknown thing but an expression without content.

Five arguments then follow. The **semantic** argument (§§1–4) holds that the objects of knowledge are ideas, that "sensible things" means what is immediately perceived, and that an apple or a tree is nothing but a collection of such ideas; since ideas cannot exist unperceived, for sensible things *to be is to be perceived* (§3). The **likeness principle** (§8) holds that an idea can be like nothing but an idea, and that a resemblance to an unperceivable original could never be checked, which destroys Locke's representative relation. The **parity** argument (§§9–15) extends Locke's own relativity considerations from secondary to primary qualities, leaving nothing for matter to be. The **Master Argument** (§§22–23) challenges us to conceive an unconceived body and answers that in conceiving it we conceive it. Finally, since ideas are passive yet arrive involuntarily in settled order, an active infinite spirit must produce and sustain them (§§30–33): reality is spirits and their ideas.

Moore attacks the inference from "experienced" to "dependent on experience" by distinguishing the **act** of awareness from its **object**: awareness of blue is not identical with blue. His transparency argument yields direct realism, on which the object is presented through, but not constituted by, consciousness.

Russell also refuses idealism, but instead of restoring the ordinary object he reconstructs it: physical objects are **logical constructions** from sense-data, perspectives and relations, so what is preserved is structure rather than the familiar thing.

Verdict. ⚠ Both refuse to reduce object to act, but they differ in what they save: Moore **defends** the ordinary object as directly known; Russell **replaces** it and retains only structural objectivity. Moore restores common sense; Russell restores science.

Qualification and criticism

note that the identification at §3 is a definition, which is why Moore's attack is on an inference and Russell's on an ontology.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2018 Q3(a): the third limb is the discriminator. Many scripts report both reactions and never contrast them, forfeiting a third of the question.

Exam-length execution — 20 marks, about 340 to 400 words: anti-abstraction in three lines; the five arguments in a compact paragraph each named; Moore in three lines; Russell in three; the contrast and verdict in three.

- **Structure:** ground clearing → five named arguments → two reactions → explicit contrast.
- **Doctrine:** abstraction, *esse est percipi*, likeness, parity, master, continuity; act-object; logical construction.
- **Evidence:** *Principles* Intro §§6–25 and §§1–4, 8, 9–15, 22–23, 30–33.
- **Distinction:** defending the ordinary object versus replacing it with a construction.
- **Criticism:** note that the identification at §3 is a definition, which is why Moore's attack is on an inference and Russell's on an ontology.

2019 · Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: Is there any element of necessity in causal relations according to Hume? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Is there any element ...? Discuss" — a yes-and-no with a distinction , never a flat denial
Core issue	Where necessity is located once it is not found in the objects
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the search, the internal find, both definitions, one qualification
Ideal thesis	Not in objects; yes in the mind, as an impression of reflection
Non-negotiables	Constant conjunction, priority, contiguity; the failed internal search; impression of reflection; two definitions

Independent model answer

Yes and no, and the distinction is the answer. In the **objects** there is no element of necessity; in the **mind** there is.

Hume applies the copy principle: if we have a genuine idea of necessary connexion, an impression must be produced. The external search fails. In a single instance of one billiard ball striking another, sense delivers only temporal **priority**, spatial **contiguity** and, across instances, **constant conjunction**. No impression of a power or tie is given, and repetition adds no new quality to the objects — the hundredth collision is qualitatively identical to the first.

The internal search fails as well. I have no impression of *how* the will moves a limb; the nerve and muscle are unknown to consciousness. This closes the Cartesian and occasionalist escape routes together.

What repetition does change is the observer. After constant conjunction the mind is **determined** to pass from the idea of the cause to that of the effect, and that felt determination is an **impression of reflection**. The idea of necessary connexion is copied from it, so necessity "is something that exists in the mind, not in objects".

Two definitions of cause follow: an object followed by another where all similar objects are so followed, and an object whose appearance conveys the thought to the other. The first is objective and regularity-based, the second psychological.

Verdict. ⚠️ There is a real element of necessity, but it is **subjective**: a fact about us, not about nature. Hume relocates necessity rather than abolishing it — and the two definitions he leaves unreconciled are the origin of the modern dispute between regularity and projectivist accounts.

Qualification and criticism

the two definitions pull apart and Hume never reconciles them.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2019 Q4(b): the word "any" makes a flat "no" wrong. Open with the distinction, then justify it.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: the distinction in one line; the external search in five; the internal search in three; the impression of reflection in four; both definitions in three; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** distinction → external search → internal search → the positive find → both definitions → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** copy principle; constant conjunction; impression of reflection; custom.
- **Evidence:** the billiard balls; the volition case; *Treatise* I.iii.14 and *Enquiry* VII.
- **Distinction:** objective necessity denied, subjective necessity affirmed.
- **Criticism:** the two definitions pull apart and Hume never reconciles them.

2020 · Q2(a) · 20 marks

Question: "I never can catch myself at any time without perception, and never can observe anything but the perception." How does this statement by Hume problematize the philosophical notion of personal identity? How does Kant deal with this problem in his Critique of Pure Reason?

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Quotation-led, two limbs: how it problematises , then how Kant deals with it
Core issue	The absence of a constant impression of the self, and the formal condition Kant substitutes
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: the argument, the fiction of unity, the Appendix, then apperception with its limit
Ideal thesis	Hume dissolves the substantial self; Kant supplies a formal condition of unity, not a soul
Non-negotiables	Copy principle; bundle formula; resemblance and causation; Appendix retraction; "I think"; transcendental unity of apperception

Independent model answer

The sentence is the copy principle turned on the perceiver. If every legitimate idea traces to an impression, an idea of the self would require an impression constant and invariable through a whole life. Introspection delivers no such thing — only heat and cold, light and shade, love and hatred, pain and pleasure, succeeding one another in perpetual flux, and never the one who is finding them.

Hume's conclusion follows: the self is "nothing but a bundle or collection of different perceptions" (*Treatise* I.iv.6). The problem this creates is threefold. First, the **substantial** self is dissolved, so nothing owns the experiences and no bearer survives change. Second, **diachronic identity** loses its ground: the unity we feel is a fiction produced by **resemblance** and **causation**, which let the imagination pass smoothly along the series and mistake an easy transition for an identical object. Third, and most damagingly, the **Appendix** confesses that Hume cannot state the principle that unites the perceptions: "all my hopes vanish". Having denied both a substance and any real connexion between distinct existences, he has removed every resource such a principle could use — and the *Enquiry* silently drops the topic altogether.

Kant does not answer by restoring a soul. He **accepts** that no inner intuition reveals a simple substance, so the rational psychologist's argument is conceded to Hume. His move is transcendental: the "**I think**" must be able to accompany all my representations if they are to belong to one experience at all. The **transcendental unity of apperception** is therefore a formal condition of synthesising a manifold under rules — not a further item discoverable inside the bundle, and not an intuition of an enduring substance.

Verdict. ⚠️ Kant answers the missing unity at the level of possible experience without proving an immortal self or a simple substance. The Humean may reply that a condition of description is not the discovery of a subject; Kant concedes the non-entity point and insists that rule-governed unity is presupposed by judgment. The exchange shows that the fault lay in the **atomism of impressions**, not in the self.

Qualification and criticism

the failure indicts atomism; the *Enquiry* silently drops the topic.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2020 Q2(a): the empiricist argument must be **complete** before Kant appears. A script that rushes to Kant loses the first limb.

Exam-length execution — 20 marks, about 340 to 400 words: the derivation in five lines; the three problems in six; Kant in six; the verdict in four.

- **Structure:** derivation → three problems → the Appendix → Kant's formal condition → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** copy principle; bundle; fiction of identity; apperception.
- **Evidence:** *Treatise* I.iv.6 and the Appendix; the "I think" formula.
- **Distinction:** a formal condition of experience versus an observed entity.
- **Criticism:** the failure indicts atomism; the *Enquiry* silently drops the topic.

2021 · Q1(c) · 10 marks

Question: "Sensible things are those only which are immediately perceived by sense." Explain Berkeley's theory of knowledge with reference to the above statement.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain ... with reference to the above statement" — the sentence must be used , not decorated
Core issue	The force of the word immediately and what it excludes
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the definition, the exclusion of inference, <i>esse est percipi</i> , one consequence
Ideal thesis	"Immediately" excludes Locke's mediated perception, and with it the veil and the matter behind it
Non-negotiables	Ideas as objects of knowledge; the collection thesis; §3; direct perception; no veil

Independent model answer

The sentence fixes a definition, and the whole theory follows from it. For Berkeley the objects of human knowledge are **ideas** — imprinted on the senses, perceived by attending to the mind's own operations, or formed by memory and imagination. A "sensible thing" is by definition what is **immediately** perceived by sense.

The word *immediately* is doing the work. Locke held that we perceive ideas which **represent** external objects, so that the object is reached mediately, by inference. Berkeley's definition removes the inference: if what is immediately perceived is an idea, and a sensible thing is what is immediately perceived, then an apple, a stone or a tree is nothing but a collection of such ideas.

Two consequences follow at once. First, the "veil of perception" disappears, and with it the sceptical problem it generated. Second, since ideas cannot exist unperceived, for sensible things *to be is to be perceived* (*Principles* §3), and "absolute existence without relation to their being perceived" is unintelligible.

Verdict. ⚠ Berkeley's theory of knowledge is direct realism about ideas: we know the world itself, not a representation of it — though the price is that the world is not material.

Qualification and criticism

note that the identification of thing with collection is a definition, which is where objections must strike.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2021 Q1(c): the quoted line is a **definition of "sensible thing"**. An answer that never analyses "immediately" has not used the statement.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: the definition in three lines; the contrast with Locke in three; the two consequences in four; verdict in one.

- **Structure:** definition → the force of "immediately" → contrast with mediated perception → consequences.
- **Doctrine:** ideas as objects of knowledge; the collection thesis; *esse est percipi*.
- **Evidence:** *Principles* §§1–4 and §3.
- **Distinction:** immediate versus mediate perception.
- **Criticism:** note that the identification of thing with collection is a definition, which is where objections must strike.

2021 · Q1(d) · 10 marks

Question: Examine the concept of personal identity by Locke.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Examine" — state and test; a ruling on the objections is required

Element	Requirement
Core issue	Whether continuity of consciousness can constitute identity
Scope boundary	Ten marks: three identities, the criterion, one case, two objections, one verdict
Ideal thesis	Forensically indispensable, metaphysically incomplete
Non-negotiables	Person/man/substance; II.xxvii.9; appropriation; forensic; prince and cobbler; Butler–Reid; Brave Officer

Independent model answer

Locke separates three questions his predecessors ran together: sameness of **substance**, sameness of **man** (the continuing living organism), and sameness of **person**. Only the third is his subject.

A person is "a thinking intelligent being, that has reason and reflection, and can consider itself as itself, the same thinking thing, in different times and places" (*Essay* II.xxvii.9, added in the second edition of 1694). Identity of person therefore extends as far as present **consciousness** can **appropriate** a past thought or action as its own. Memory is the vehicle and evidence of that reach, not the definition. "Person" is, in Locke's own word, **forensic**: it is built for accountability.

The prince-and-cobbler case makes the separation vivid: transfer the prince's consciousness and the **person** who wakes is the prince while the **man** is the cobbler.

Two objections press hard. Butler and Reid charge **circularity**, since I can remember only my own experiences. Reid's **Brave Officer** shows the criterion is not transitive: the officer remembers the boy, the general remembers the officer, the general does not remember the boy.

Verdict. ⚠️ Repaired as overlapping chains of consciousness, the theory survives Reid; the circularity charge remains open. Forensically indispensable, metaphysically incomplete.

Qualification and criticism

the repair costs the simple memory reading.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2021 Q1(d): "Examine" is a two-part instruction. Doctrine alone, however accurate, caps the mark.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: three identities in two lines; definition and criterion in four; the case in two; objections in three; verdict in one.

- **Structure:** three identities → definition → criterion → case → objections → graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** consciousness, appropriation, forensic concept.
- **Evidence:** II.xxvii.9; the 1694 addition; prince and cobbler; the Brave Officer.
- **Distinction:** constitutive criterion versus evidential criterion.
- **Criticism:** the repair costs the simple memory reading.

2021 · Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: "The relation between cause and effect is one of constant conjunction". Examine Hume's criticism of causation in the light of the above statement.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Examine ... in the light of the statement" — the quoted phrase must be tested, not merely repeated
Core issue	Whether constant conjunction exhausts the analysis
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the three observables, the missing power, the internal find, one qualification
Ideal thesis	Constant conjunction is necessary but not sufficient; the felt determination completes the account
Non-negotiables	Priority, contiguity, constant conjunction; no impression of power; impression of reflection; custom

Independent model answer

The quoted sentence is accurate but incomplete, and examining it is the answer.

Hume's analysis begins with what observation supplies: temporal **priority**, spatial **contiguity** and, across repeated instances, **constant conjunction**. What observation never supplies is a **power** or **tie** binding cause to effect. Applying the copy principle, Hume asks which impression the idea of necessary connexion is copied from. No external impression answers, and repetition adds nothing to the objects themselves.

The internal route also fails: I have no impression of how the will moves a limb.

What repetition does alter is the mind. After constant conjunction it is **determined** to pass from the idea of the cause to that of the effect, and this felt determination is an **impression of reflection** from which the idea of necessity is copied. Causal necessity is therefore projected onto objects, not read off them, and the mechanism is **custom or habit**.

Verdict. ⚠️ Constant conjunction alone is mere regularity; Hume's account requires priority, contiguity **and** the felt determination. He does not deny causation — he relocates its necessity from the world to the observer.

Qualification and criticism

"mere succession" is the misreading the quoted line invites.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2021 Q1(e): the examiner supplies a partial formula. The mark is for showing what it omits.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: the three observables in three lines; the failed searches in four; the impression of reflection in three; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** what is observed → what is not → the internal search → the positive find → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** copy principle; constant conjunction; impression of reflection; custom.
- **Evidence:** the billiard-ball case; *Treatise* I.iii.14; *Enquiry* VII.
- **Distinction:** regularity versus the full analysis including felt necessity.
- **Criticism:** "mere succession" is the misreading the quoted line invites.

2022 · Q4(c) · 15 marks

Question: Why and how does John Locke refute the innate ideas? Elucidate the nature and source of knowledge in Locke's epistemology.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Two limbs: why and how he refutes, then elucidate nature and source of knowledge
Core issue	The three grounds and the positive replacement they make room for
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: motive, three grounds, two fountains, simple/complex, degrees, one qualification
Ideal thesis	The refutation clears space for a genetic account; it defeats naive but not dispositional innatism
Non-negotiables	Universal assent; no unconscious ideas; redundancy; II.i.2; sensation and reflection; the three degrees

Independent model answer

Why. Locke's target is the claim that certain ideas and principles are stamped on the mind at birth. If true, it would license appeals to authority that no experience could check, and it would make an account of the *origin* of ideas unnecessary. Locke wants the origin of an idea to be the test of its legitimacy, so the innatist hypothesis must go first.

How. Three grounds, in Book I. First, **universal assent fails**: if such ideas were innate, all human beings including children would possess them, and they do not. Second, **there are no unconscious ideas**: a thought the mind does not think is self-contradictory, since to be in the mind is to be perceived by the mind. Third, a **genetic account is available**: every alleged innate idea, including God and non-contradiction, can be traced to experience, so the hypothesis is redundant.

The positive account. The mind is "white paper, void of all characters" (II.i.2) — the doctrine traditionally labelled *tabula rasa*, though the Latin is not Locke's. Experience has two channels: **sensation**, giving ideas of external objects, and **reflection**, giving ideas of the mind's own operations. **Simple** ideas are passively received; the understanding actively forms **complex** ideas as modes, substances and relations.

Knowledge is then the **perception of the agreement or disagreement of ideas**, in three degrees: **intuitive** (immediate), **demonstrative** (through intervening ideas) and **sensitive** (of particular existing things). Everything below is probability and judgement.

Verdict. ⚠️ Locke defeats naive innatism decisively; against Descartes' **dispositional** innatism his empirical grounds miss, and everything rests on the premise about what "in the mind" means — a stipulation rather than a discovery.

Qualification and criticism

the decisive ground is a stipulation about the meaning of "idea".

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2022 Q4(c): two limbs, two headings. The second limb is not an afterthought: "nature and source" means the definition of knowledge **and** its two fountains.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: motive in three lines; three grounds in six; the positive account in six; the degrees in three; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** why → three grounds → sources → nature and degrees → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** anti-innatism; sensation and reflection; simple and complex ideas; the three degrees.
- **Evidence:** *Essay* Book I; II.i.2; the classification at II.xii.
- **Distinction:** naive versus dispositional innatism.
- **Criticism:** the decisive ground is a stipulation about the meaning of "idea".

2023 · Q2(a) · 20 marks

Question: Critically analyse Hume's argument that causality is a matter of habit/custom involving psychological principle of association.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Critically analyse" — exposition plus a delivered verdict
Core issue	Whether reducing causal necessity to habit is an explanation or a capitulation
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: full analysis, both definitions, association, three objections, ruling
Ideal thesis	Hume succeeds against experience-based grounding of necessity; the result follows from his atomism
Non-negotiables	Three observables; failed internal search; impression of reflection; both definitions; practice versus justification

Independent model answer

Causation is the hinge on which empiricism's critique of metaphysics and science's rational basis both turn, so the argument deserves close statement before assessment.

The analysis. Observation of one event producing another delivers temporal **priority**, spatial **contiguity** and **constant conjunction**. It never delivers a power or tie. Applying the copy principle, Hume looks for the impression from which the idea of necessary connexion could be copied. The external search fails, and

repetition adds no new quality to the objects. The internal search fails too: I have no impression of how volition moves a limb, which closes the Cartesian and occasionalist routes at once.

The positive account. Repetition changes the observer. After constant conjunction the mind is **determined** to pass from cause to effect; that determination is an **impression of reflection**, and the idea of necessity is copied from it. The mechanism is the **association** of ideas by resemblance, contiguity and causation, and the resulting expectation is **custom**, "the great guide of human life". Two definitions of cause follow — one objective and regularity-based, one psychological, conveying the thought to the other — and Hume never reconciles them.

Assessment. Three objections press. **Kant** replies that causality is an *a priori* rule required to distinguish objective succession from the subjective succession of perceptions, so necessity is contributed by the understanding rather than observed in objects. **Pragmatically**, the success of science suggests a real causal order — though Hume answers that success is a psychological fact about creatures built to expect, not a justification. **Self-referentially**, if inference is mere habit, Hume's own arguments lose their force; his defence is that he distinguishes the **practice** of inference, which nature compels, from its **justification**, which reason cannot supply.

Verdict. ⚠️ Hume establishes that experience alone cannot ground causal necessity. But the result follows from the **atomism of impressions**: if perceptions are separable atoms, no relation can be perceived, and the conclusion is guaranteed by the premise. Kant's reply is therefore correctly aimed, since it attacks the atomism rather than the inference — while Hume's sceptical result stands as a permanent constraint on dogmatic metaphysics.

Qualification and criticism

the atomism of impressions guarantees the conclusion.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2023 Q2(a): "critically analyse" requires a ruling. Exposition alone, however complete, cannot reach the top band.

Exam-length execution — 20 marks, about 340 to 400 words: frame in two lines; analysis in seven; positive account in six; three objections in six; verdict in four.

- **Structure:** frame → analysis → positive account → three objections → ruling.
- **Doctrine:** copy principle; association; custom; two definitions.
- **Evidence:** billiard balls and bread; *Treatise* I.iii.14; *Enquiry* IV, V, VII.
- **Distinction:** the practice of causal inference versus its justification.
- **Criticism:** the atomism of impressions guarantees the conclusion.

2024 · Q2(a) · 20 marks

Question: Is rejection of Locke's notion of primary qualities instrumental in Berkeley's leaning towards idealism? In this context, also discuss how subjective idealism is different from the absolute idealism proposed by Hegel.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Two limbs: an instrumentality verdict , then a comparison
Core issue	Which rejection actually does the work, and how two idealisms differ in kind
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: the quality distinction, parity and likeness, the abstraction ground, then matched axes for Hegel
Ideal thesis	Yes, but instrumentally through the likeness principle and anti-abstraction, not through relativity alone
Non-negotiables	Primary/secondary lists; §§8, 9–15; abstraction as the deeper ground; Berkeley subjective and theistic; Hegel objective and dialectical

Independent model answer

Yes — but the answer must say **which** rejection is instrumental, since Berkeley uses two different weapons and only one of them is decisive.

Locke divides **primary** qualities — solidity, extension, figure, motion or rest, number — which are inseparable from body and whose ideas **resemble** them, from **secondary** qualities such as colour and warmth, which are **powers** to produce sensations and whose ideas resemble nothing.

Berkeley's first weapon is **parity** (*Principles* §§9–15): every relativity consideration Locke accepts against secondary qualities applies to primary ones as well — apparent size varies with distance, motion with frame of reference, shape with angle of view. This is suggestive but not decisive, since a realist may reply that varying appearance is exactly what a mind-independent shape would produce.

The decisive weapon is the **likeness principle** (§8): "an idea can be like nothing but an idea", and a resemblance to an unperceivable original could never be checked. That removes the last property matter was supposed to have in its own right. Behind both lies the deeper ground: the attack on **abstract general ideas**, since Locke's *material substance in general* is the abstract idea of being plus the relative notion of supporting. Once abstraction fails, matter is meaningless rather than unknown, and only spirits and ideas remain.

Subjective versus absolute idealism. For Berkeley, reality is **ideas in finite and divine minds**; sensible existence *consists in* being perceived, and an infinite spirit causes and coordinates the ideas of sense while sustaining what finite minds do not perceive. For Hegel, reality is the **self-development of Absolute Spirit**, in which objectivity is a moment within a dialectical process driven by determinate negation; the Absolute is not an external perceiver preserving private idea-collections, and its method is developmental rather than perceptual.

Verdict. ⚠ The rejection of primary qualities is instrumental, but as a *removal* rather than a *proof*: it clears matter away, while the positive idealism comes from the anti-abstraction argument and from the argument to an active infinite spirit. And Berkeley's theistic subjective idealism is not an early Hegelianism — the two differ in **kind**, not in degree.

Qualification and criticism

relativity alone does not entail mind-dependence.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2024 Q2(a): "instrumental" asks for a causal-explanatory ruling, not a narration of two doctrines.

Exam-length execution — 20 marks, about 340 to 400 words: the distinction in three lines; parity in four; likeness and abstraction in six; the comparison in six; verdict in three.

- **Structure:** the distinction → parity → likeness → abstraction → matched-axis comparison → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** qualities; likeness; parity; abstraction; two idealisms.
- **Evidence:** *Essay* II.viii; *Principles* §§8, 9–15 and Intro §§6–25.
- **Distinction:** removal versus proof; subjective versus absolute idealism.
- **Criticism:** relativity alone does not entail mind-dependence.

2025 · Q2(c) · 15 marks

Question: Examine Hume's refutation of Causal relation and Kant's response to it.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Examine" both limbs — state each, then test whether Kant's answer succeeds
Core issue	Whether the Second Analogy answers Hume or presupposes what it must prove
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: Hume compressed but complete, Kant precise, one adjudication
Ideal thesis	Kant accepts Hume's negative result and attacks the atomism that produced it
Non-negotiables	No impression of necessary connexion; custom; both definitions; Second Analogy; synthetic a priori; things in themselves

Independent model answer

Hume. Observation of causal sequences delivers only temporal priority, spatial contiguity and constant conjunction; no impression of a power or tie is given, and repetition adds nothing to the objects. The internal route through volition fails equally. What repetition alters is the mind, which after constant conjunction is **determined** to pass from cause to effect — an **impression of reflection** from which the idea of necessity is copied. Hence two definitions of cause: regular succession of similars, and an object whose appearance conveys the thought to the other. The consequence is that inductive inference rests on **custom**, not reason.

Kant. He does not dispute the negative finding; he agrees that necessary connexion is not copied from a sensory impression. His answer is transcendental. In the **Second Analogy** the category of cause is an *a priori* rule required to distinguish an **objective** succession of events from the merely **subjective**

succession of my perceptions. "Every event has a cause" is therefore **synthetic a priori** for possible experience: the understanding supplies necessary temporal ordering to phenomena, and objective empirical causation is rescued without any claim about causality among things in themselves.

Examination. The Humean challenge is that Kant has built the category into the definition of objective experience rather than proving it. Kant's reply is that without rule-governed synthesis, experience of an **event** would not be possible, so the presupposition is a condition of the fact to be explained.

Verdict. ⚠️ Kant is correctly aimed: Hume's conclusion follows from the **atomism of impressions**, and it is that atomism, not the inference, which Kant attacks. Whether a condition of possible experience amounts to knowledge of nature remains contested — which is why the answer should close by grading, not by declaring a winner.

Qualification and criticism

does Kant prove the category or presuppose it?

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2025 Q2(c): the Hume limb must be complete before Kant begins; ownership discipline is itself a mark.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: Hume in nine lines; Kant in seven; the examination in four; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** Hume → Kant → the challenge and reply → graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** copy principle; custom; two definitions; Second Analogy; synthetic a priori.
- **Evidence:** *Treatise* I.iii.14; *Enquiry* IV and VII; the ship-and-house contrast.
- **Distinction:** objective event-succession versus subjective succession of perceptions.
- **Criticism:** does Kant prove the category or presuppose it?

2025 · Q4(c) · 15 marks

Question: Explain Berkeley's doctrine of nominalism and his refutation of Abstract ideas.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain" — exhibit the derivation , not the conclusion
Core issue	The doctrine refuted, the refutation, the replacement, and the metaphysical payload
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: Locke's doctrine compressed, Berkeley's steps, the positive account, the consequence for matter
Ideal thesis	Nominalism is the foundation of immaterialism, not a corollary of it
Non-negotiables	III.iii and IV.vii.9; Intro §§6–25; §§12, 13, 19–20; matter as abstract general idea

Independent model answer

The doctrine refuted. For Locke everything that exists is particular, yet most words are general; words become general by signifying **general ideas**, and ideas become general by **abstraction** — separation from circumstances of time, place and every concomitant idea (*Essay* III.iii.6–9). That "general representative" is the **nominal essence**. Locke himself concedes that the general idea of a triangle must be "neither oblique nor rectangle, neither equilateral, equicrural, nor scalenon; but all and none of these at once", and that it is "something imperfect, that cannot exist" (IV.vii.9).

The refutation. Berkeley concedes that we may separate what **could** exist apart — a hand from a body, a torso from a head. He denies that we may separate what **cannot**: extension without colour, motion without determinate speed, "man" without stature. He then quotes Locke's own triangle sentence verbatim at *Principles*, Introduction §13, and concludes that no such idea can be framed. Therefore there are no abstract general ideas.

The replacement — nominalism proper. An idea is general not by being abstract but "by being made to represent or stand for all other particular ideas of the same sort" (Intro §12). A determinate particular idea, **selectively attended to**, does duty for a class: the geometer draws this black inch-long line and proves a theorem about all lines. Berkeley adds that words need not stand for ideas at all (§§19–20).

The payload. Locke's *material substance in general* is precisely an abstract general idea — the abstract idea of being plus the relative notion of supporting. If abstraction is impossible, "matter" is not a mysterious unknown but a **meaningless expression**, so immaterialism rests on the nominalism.

Verdict. ⚠️ Decisive against an **imagistic** Locke; against a **determinable** reading the objection misses, and Berkeley still owes an account of what fixes the respect of representation.

Qualification and criticism

the determinable reading of Locke, and the unfixed respect of representation.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2025 Q4(c): the refutation cannot be explained without the doctrine refuted. Give Locke first, compressed but exact.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: Locke in six lines; the refutation in five; the replacement in five; the payload in three; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** doctrine refuted → refutation → positive replacement → metaphysical payload → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** abstraction; nominal essence; representative use; language beyond ideas.
- **Evidence:** IV.vii.9 quoted at *Principles* Intro §13; §12; §§19–20.
- **Distinction:** separating what could exist apart versus what could not.
- **Criticism:** the determinable reading of Locke, and the unfixed respect of representation.

2026 · Q1(b) · 10 marks

Question: Explain the distinction between Intuitive knowledge and Demonstrative knowledge as propounded by Locke.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain the distinction" — define the common genus, then distinguish mode, certainty and examples
Core issue	Immediate versus mediate perception of agreement/disagreement among ideas
Scope boundary	Ten marks: definition, two degrees, relation between them, sensitive knowledge in one line
Ideal thesis	Demonstration is a memory-dependent chain of intuitions, not probability
Non-negotiables	<i>Essay</i> IV.i.2 and IV.ii; intervening ideas/proofs; mathematics/God; sensitive knowledge

Independent model answer

Locke defines knowledge as the perception of the connection and agreement, or disagreement and repugnancy, among our ideas (*Essay* IV.i.2). Intuitive and demonstrative knowledge differ not in their subject matter but in **how** this agreement is perceived.

In **intuitive knowledge**, the mind perceives the agreement or disagreement of two ideas immediately, without any intervening idea. "White is not black," "three is more than two," and one's own existence are Locke's standard kinds of case. Such knowledge is irresistible, leaves no room for doubt and supplies the clearest light available to the understanding.

In **demonstrative knowledge**, the termini cannot be compared at one view. The mind introduces intermediate ideas or "proofs," perceiving intuitively that each neighbouring pair agrees. Demonstration is therefore a **chain of intuitions**. Mathematical proofs and Locke's proof of God exemplify it. It remains certain, but is less clear and ready than intuition because it takes time and attention, depends on memory of earlier steps, and permits error through an omitted or misremembered link.

Locke also recognizes **sensitive knowledge** of presently existing particular things, ranking it below both.

Verdict. Intuition is immediate evidence; demonstration is mediate certainty derived through intuitively certified links. Demonstration is not mere probability.

Qualification and criticism

Locke's ranking is coherent if "degree" describes the mode and luminosity of evidence. Yet fallible memory makes long demonstrations practically less secure, while sensitive knowledge strains his definition because external existence is not simply an agreement between two ideas.

Why this earns marks

- Defines Locke's genus before drawing the distinction.
- Explains why demonstration remains knowledge while ranking below intuition.
- Uses canonical examples and names the anomalous third degree without losing focus.
- Ends with the close-option distinction most often missed: demonstrative does not mean probable.

Exam-length execution

Write about 150–200 words: definition in two lines; intuition in four; demonstration and its dependence on intuitive links in six; sensitive knowledge and qualification in two.

Closed-book answer spine

agreement/disagreement → immediate/no middle → mediate/proofs → chain of intuitions → attention + memory → sensitive third degree → certain, not probable

2026 · Q2(b) · 15 marks

Question: How does Hume account for ideas of reason? How does Kant respond to Hume's views in this regard? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Two expository limbs plus critical assessment
Core issue	Hume's empirical genesis and limited rational necessity; Kant's synthetic-a-priori reply
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: copy principle, association and fork; Kant's categories and phenomenal limit
Ideal thesis	Hume confines necessity to relations among ideas or mental habit; Kant relocates objective necessity to conditions of experience
Non-negotiables	impressions/ideas; relations of ideas/matters of fact; causality; categories; synthetic a priori; phenomena

Independent model answer

Hume accounts for ideas by subordinating reason to experiential content. All perceptions divide into vivid **impressions** and fainter **ideas**; every simple idea normally copies a prior simple impression. Complex thought is formed by memory, imagination and the principles of association — resemblance, contiguity and cause/effect. Reason can compare these contents, but cannot originate a simple content for which no impression can be found.

Hume's fork fixes reason's legitimate reach. **Relations of ideas**, such as " $2 + 2 = 4$," are necessary and knowable by thought because their denial is contradictory; they clarify relations among ideas but assert no existence. **Matters of fact** depend on experience, and their contraries remain conceivable. Consequently reason cannot discover an objective necessary tie between cause and effect. Repetition produces custom and a felt transition of thought, not a rational insight into power.

Kant says Hume awakened him from dogmatic slumber. He accepts that necessity cannot be copied from sensation, but denies that it is therefore merely habitual. Sensibility gives a manifold; the understanding actively unifies it through **a priori categories**, including causality. Principles such as "every event has a cause" are **synthetic a priori** conditions under which an objective temporal succession can be

experienced at all. Necessity is thus supplied by the knowing subject and is valid for phenomena, not things-in-themselves. The Second Analogy sharpens the reply: objective succession must be rule-governed, not merely expected through habit.

Verdict. Kant preserves Hume's anti-dogmatic limit while rejecting his psychology of necessity. He secures objective science within experience, though at the cost of restricting knowledge to appearances.

Qualification and criticism

Hume can object that Kant explains what experience must presuppose only by introducing a transcendental framework not itself derived from impressions. Kant's reply is that categories are not inferred entities but conditions demonstrated by the possibility of objective experience. The answer succeeds only if that transcendental argument is accepted.

Why this earns marks

- Accounts for both the genesis and classification of ideas rather than reducing Hume to one slogan.
- Completes Hume's causal consequence before introducing Kant.
- States Kant's response as transcendental, synthetic a priori and phenomenon-limited.
- Gives a balanced criticism instead of presenting Kant as an uncontested refutation.

Exam-length execution

Write about 250–300 words: Hume's copy-and-association account in five lines; the fork and causal limit in six; Kant's category response in seven; criticism and verdict in three.

Closed-book answer spine

impression → simple idea → association → fork → no factual necessity from reason →
Humean custom → Kantian category → synthetic a priori → objective phenomena, no
noumena

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Six original questions in the UPSC idiom — two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks — with complete model solutions inside the same word bands. These are practice items, not predictions.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Is Locke's description of substance as "something, I know not what" an admission of ignorance or an abandonment of the concept? Examine.

Independent model answer

It is an admission of ignorance, and the distinction is exact.

Locke observes that we meet clusters of qualities that regularly go together — yellow, heavy, malleable, soluble in aqua regia — and cannot conceive them as subsisting on their own. We therefore **suppose** a support. But no impression of that support is ever presented, so we have "a supposition of he knows not what support of such qualities" (*Essay* II.xxiii.2).

Two things are denied and one is affirmed. Denied: any **positive idea** of the substratum, and any knowledge of the **real essence** it embodies. Affirmed: that something is qualified, since qualities do not float.

The concept is therefore retained as an **explanatory posit** tied to the stability of kinds, not abandoned. Berkeley's counter is that "support" here is a dead metaphor, and that removing it leaves the abstract idea of being conjoined with a relative notion — an abstract general idea.

Verdict. ⚠ Ignorance, not abandonment; but the posit's intelligibility depends on a doctrine of abstraction that Berkeley attacks, so Locke's humility is stable only while that doctrine holds.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the question offers a false dichotomy, and the mark is for refusing it precisely.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: the ruling in one line; the derivation in four; denied-and-affirmed in three; Berkeley in two; verdict in two.

- **Structure:** ruling → derivation → what is denied and affirmed → the counter → graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** substratum; real essence; explanatory posit.
- **Evidence:** *Essay* II.xxiii.2.
- **Distinction:** no positive idea versus no existence.
- **Criticism:** the posit depends on abstraction.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Berkeley holds that we have a "notion" of spirit though no idea of it. Is this distinction principled or merely convenient? Discuss.

Independent model answer

It is principled in its motive and vulnerable in its result.

The motive is internal to the system. Berkeley's ideas are **passive**; a spirit is **active**, perceiving and willing. An idea, being inert, could never picture an activity, so if activity is known at all it cannot be known by an idea. Hence spirits — my own, other finite minds, and God — are known by **notion** (*Principles* §§27, 89, 140). Notions also cover relations, which likewise are not pictured.

The vulnerability is equally clear. Berkeley's case against matter was that an unperceivable substratum has no content. An unperceivable spirit, known by a faculty introduced for the purpose, invites the same complaint, and critics call the asymmetry ad hoc.

The strongest defence is that the asymmetry is **forced** rather than chosen: the objection assumes that all knowledge is idea-shaped, which is precisely what Berkeley denies once activity enters the ontology. Hume then tests the defence by refusing the exemption and dissolving spiritual substance as well.

Verdict. ⚠️ Principled in derivation, unproven in adequacy — and Hume's refusal shows exactly how much weight it was carrying.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "principled or convenient" demands a two-sided ruling, not a defence brief.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: motive in five lines; vulnerability in three; defence in three; verdict in one.

- **Structure:** motive → vulnerability → defence → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** passivity of ideas; activity of spirits; notions.
- **Evidence:** *Principles* §§27, 89, 140.
- **Distinction:** forced asymmetry versus convenient exemption.
- **Criticism:** Hume removes the exemption and the self goes with it.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: "Berkeley destroys Locke's resemblance thesis but not his distinction between primary and secondary qualities." Critically examine.

Independent model answer

The statement is largely correct, and stating why requires separating two theses Locke runs together.

Thesis A — the explanatory distinction. Primary qualities are solidity, extension, figure, motion or rest and number: they are inseparable from body, since every fragment retains them, and they are the properties a corpuscular physics must attribute to any body. Secondary qualities are **powers**, grounded in primary-quality configurations, to produce sensations in us.

Thesis B — the resemblance claim. Our ideas of primary qualities **resemble** the qualities themselves; our ideas of secondary qualities resemble nothing in the object.

Berkeley attacks both. His **parity** argument (*Principles* §§9–15) observes that the relativity considerations Locke accepts against secondary qualities apply equally to primary ones. But relativity does not entail mind-dependence: that a coin looks elliptical from an angle is exactly what a genuinely circular coin should produce. Thesis A therefore survives, though it must be restated as a distinction between **measurable-structural** and **response-dependent** properties rather than as a claim about what is "really in" the object.

The **likeness principle** (§8) is another matter. If an idea can be like nothing but an idea, and the alleged originals are unperceivable, then the resemblance could never be checked and the claim is empty. Thesis B falls. The available rescue is **isomorphism**: structural correspondence requires no qualitative likeness, as a map corresponds to terrain without being terrain-coloured — but this concedes Berkeley's point about likeness and defends something weaker.

Verdict. ⚠️ Correct with one qualification: what survives is not Locke's distinction as he framed it, but its explanatory core. Locke's error was to make the division depend on a picture rather than on explanatory role — which is why physics retains the distinction while his version of it does not.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: a quotation-led "critically examine" requires you to grade the quotation, not merely to agree.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: the two theses in seven lines; parity in five; likeness in five; verdict in four.

- **Structure:** separate the theses → parity against A → likeness against B → graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** quality lists; powers; resemblance; isomorphism.
- **Evidence:** *Essay* II.viii; *Principles* §§8 and 9–15.
- **Distinction:** measurable-structural versus response-dependent properties.
- **Criticism:** the survivor is the explanatory core, not Locke's own formulation.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Hume's Appendix confesses that he cannot explain what unites successive perceptions. Does this failure refute the bundle theory or diagnose a deeper problem? Discuss.

Independent model answer

It diagnoses a deeper problem, and reading it as a simple refutation misses what Hume has shown.

The doctrine. Applying the copy principle to the perceiver, Hume finds no constant and invariable impression of a self, only perceptions in perpetual flux, and concludes that the self is "nothing but a bundle or collection of different perceptions" (*Treatise* I.iv.6). The felt unity is a fiction produced by **resemblance** and **causation**, which let the imagination pass smoothly along the series and mistake an easy transition for an identical object.

The confession. In the Appendix Hume writes that all his hopes vanish when he comes to explain the principles that unite our successive perceptions. The admission is genuine, and the *Enquiry* silently drops the topic.

What it shows. Hume has denied two things at once: any **substance** in which perceptions inhere, and any **real connexion** between distinct existences. Together these remove every resource a uniting principle could have used. The failure is therefore not an accident of ingenuity but a consequence of the **atomism of impressions** — the doctrine that perceptions are separable atoms, so that no relation is given with its terms.

The comparison that clinches it. Exactly the same atomism generates the negative result about causation, where no relation between events can be perceived either. One premise, two failures.

Verdict. ⚠ The bundle theory is not refuted by the confession; it is revealed as the last casualty of empiricist atomism. That Hume can find no principle of unity, and says so, indicts the premise rather than the self — which is precisely the diagnosis Kant makes when he supplies a formal condition of unity instead of an impression.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the question offers two readings; choose one and show why the other is superficial.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: doctrine in six lines; confession in three; diagnosis in six; comparison in two; verdict in three.

- **Structure:** doctrine → confession → diagnosis → parallel with causation → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** copy principle; bundle; fiction of identity; atomism.
- **Evidence:** *Treatise* I.iv.6 and the Appendix; the *Enquiry's* silence.
- **Distinction:** refutation of a theory versus diagnosis of a premise.
- **Criticism:** one premise produces both the missing self and the missing necessity.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "The movement from Locke through Berkeley to Hume is a logical development rather than a historical accident." Critically analyse.

Independent model answer

The claim is defensible but needs one important correction: the movement is logical only because each successor supplies an **additional premise** his predecessor could have refused.

The shared rule. All three accept that every simple cognitive content originates in experience — Locke's sensation and reflection, Hume's impressions — while retaining the mind's operations of comparing, combining and abstracting.

Locke's exemption. He applies the rule to ideas but exempts **matter**, holding that ideas of primary qualities resemble their causes and that a substratum supports co-occurring qualities, though we have "a supposition of he knows not what support" (*Essay* II.xxiii.2). Sensitive knowledge of external things is his weakest degree, so the exemption is asserted at the point of least support.

Berkeley's step, and its premise. He removes the exemption with the **likeness principle**: an idea can be like nothing but an idea, and a resemblance to an unperceivable original could never be checked (*Principles* §8). Beneath this lies the attack on abstraction, since "material substance in general" is the abstract idea of being plus the relative notion of supporting. The **added premise** is comparability — that a resemblance no perceiver could verify is empty. A determined Lockean could resist by shifting to structural correspondence, which requires no qualitative likeness.

Hume's step, and its premise. He applies the same test to what Berkeley retained: spirit and causal power. No impression of a substantial self is found, so the self becomes a bundle (*Treatise* I.iv.6); no impression of necessary connexion is found, so necessity is relocated to an impression of reflection. The **added premise** is the **atomism of impressions** — perceptions are separable, so no relation is given with its terms. Berkeley could have resisted by denying that activity must be idea-shaped, which is exactly what his doctrine of notions asserts.

Verdict. ⚠ The sequence is logical in structure and contingent in premises. Each stage is the previous position made consistent, which is why it is not a historical accident; but each stage also needs a premise that was available to be denied, which is why it is not a proof. That the rule consistently applied ends in a scepticism nobody can live is best read as a diagnosis of the rule's incompleteness — the conclusion Kant draws when he attacks the atomism rather than the inference.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: a "logical development" claim is won by exhibiting the **mechanism** and lost by narrating three systems.

Exam-length execution — 20 marks, about 340 to 400 words: shared rule in three lines; Locke in five; Berkeley in six; Hume in six; verdict in five.

- **Structure:** shared rule → exemption → two removals with their added premises → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** resemblance; likeness; abstraction; bundle; necessary connexion.
- **Evidence:** II.xxiii.2; *Principles* §8 and Intro §§6–25; *Treatise* I.iv.6 and I.iii.14.
- **Distinction:** logical structure versus contingent premises.
- **Criticism:** each added premise was resistible, so the slide explains without proving.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Compare the role assigned to God by Locke, Berkeley and Hume, and assess what each system loses if the divine premise is withdrawn.

Independent model answer

Run the comparison on one axis: **what job does God perform in the system?** Answered that way, three very different dependencies appear.

Locke — God as guarantor and conclusion. God's existence is known by **demonstration**, not intuition and not sensitive knowledge: from the intuitive certainty of my own existence, together with the principle that nothing comes from nothing, Locke infers an eternal, most powerful and most knowing being. God also does defensive work: divine non-deception supports the reliability of sense and the trustworthiness of our faculties for "the conveniences of life".

If withdrawn: the demonstration is lost, and the defence of representative realism weakens — but the epistemology survives, since the three degrees of knowledge and the two fountains of ideas stand independently.

Berkeley — God as cause and continuity. Ideas are passive; the ideas of sense arrive involuntarily in settled order; only spirits are active; therefore an infinite spirit produces them (*Principles* §§30–33). God also secures the persistence of sensible things unperceived by finite minds, and the laws of nature become the settled grammar of a divine language, so regularities are **signs** rather than causes.

If withdrawn: the system collapses. Without an active infinite spirit there is no cause of the involuntary order, no continuity for unperceived objects, and no distinction between the real and the imaginary beyond the felt vivacity of one's own ideas. God is load-bearing here in a way he is not for Locke.

Hume — God as casualty. Every proof fails. The causal argument is cut at its premise, since there is no impression of necessary connexion licensing an inference to a transcendent cause. The design argument rests on a weak analogy, and even if granted proves at most a **finite** architect working on given matter; natural principles might explain order without intelligence; and the problem of evil blocks the inference to a perfectly good designer. Testimony can never make a miracle more probable than its own falsehood.

If withdrawn: nothing is lost, because nothing was resting on it.

Verdict. ⚠️ The dependency is inversely related to the empiricism's consistency. Locke uses God as a support, Berkeley requires him as a mechanism, Hume dispenses with him as unsupported. The comparison also exposes the deepest criticism of immaterialism: God performs exactly the two functions Locke assigned to matter — causing our ideas and sustaining the unperceived — so Berkeley's economy is a substitution of posits rather than an elimination of them.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: announce the axis — the **job God performs** — in the first line, and the comparison writes itself.

Exam-length execution — 20 marks, about 340 to 400 words: axis in one line; each thinker in a paragraph with an explicit withdrawal test; verdict in four.

- **Structure:** axis → three systems each with a counterfactual test → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** demonstrative proof; divine non-deception; passivity and continuity; the three failed proofs.
- **Evidence:** *Essay IV*; *Principles* §§30–33; *Dialogues concerning Natural Religion*; *Enquiry X*.
- **Distinction:** God as support, as mechanism, and as casualty.
- **Criticism:** in Berkeley, God does matter's old job — which is the real question about the system.